Q+A

A GOOD SPORT

Based on a true story, **Abhay Deol's** latest film, *Jungle Cry* (streaming on Lionsgate Play from June 3), sees him play Rudra, a coach who helps a ragtag team of underprivileged children win the Under 14 Rugby World Cup in England

Q. Did you have knowledge of how the 12 members of the team, all students of Odisha's Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences, achieved victory in 2007? Also, were you a follower of rugby before you did *Jungle Cry*?

I was obviously aware of rugby, but had to learn much of the rules during the film's making. I was not aware of the institute and its work. The kids were underdogs, but they did something great. Unfortunately, they didn't get due recognition for their achievement.

Q. Did you meet with or interact with coach Rudraksha Jena or any of the players from that team?

The original players are older now but they came by to say hello. We shot at the institute and in the same hostel rooms where the boys stay. The kids acting in *Jungle Cry* are tribal children from the Kalinga Institute.

Q. What are some of the themes of the film?

It addresses the fact that there is a diversity of communities, talents and sport in this country that are not given the attention they should get. And what these opportunities mean to children who do not have the privilege of an education. It is survival for them and the film shows how hard they work.

Q. What is driving your professional decisions these days?

It hasn't changed. I always look for a script and a character I can relate to—something that is being true to itself and not catering to anyone or any market. I want to work with people with a unique voice, people who want to be heard. I am very satisfied with where I am and what I have done.

Q. What is it like having two home bases?

I have done the flight from India to America so often now, I don't even get jet lag anymore. All my immediate family is in Los Angeles and I have friends there, so LA is also home now.

—with Udita Jhunjhunwala



RUBINA A. KHAN/GETTY IMAGES